This was most evident in regard to energy imports from Russia, though it also extends to other aspects of commerce.

Even if the smoke clears somewhat, what would be of great interest to India are Europe's changed relationships across the Atlantic and towards the Urals. Both are likely to encourage a re-evaluation of its Asian engagement. The big imponderables are the future of a German posture so assiduously built over two decades and how much others will seek to take advantage of its ongoing dilemma. Where Asia is concerned, European positions will necessarily be different from the US because it is no longer defending global supremacy. At the same time, risk awareness has certainly grown in recent years. In many ways, the outcomes will be a compromise between pressing compulsions and medium-term calculations.

It is, however, the premier power of our times that is the bellwether of change. Influential Americans have argued that a less globally dominant US cannot afford the economically generous stance of the past. Their reservations are no longer restricted to just free trade agreements but also extend to the nature of global supply chains. As a result, more innovative endeavours are made to intensify economic engagements abroad that are sensitive to the realities at home. An example is the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF), which commenced on the sidelines of the 2022 Quad Summit in Tokyo and has progressed by the time of the 2023 Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) meeting.

It is not only that the US is looking to realize opportunities differently. The strategy that it fashioned in respect of the Ukraine conflict has also been instructive in highlighting the vulnerabilities of our era. Indeed, the entire game has become one of which party is able to better leverage its hold on the other. A key question is the American ability to address multiple major challenges simultaneously. And of course, that is precisely what distinguishes the dominant power of our times from others. American awareness of strategic competition is greater, and is combined with domestic compulsions to build and protect better. The aggregate of these developments, some long in the making and others more immediate, are truly transformational.

What we are currently experiencing is also being shaped by concerns that go beyond the orthodox belief in Westphalian politics. Admittedly, the Cold War saw systemic competition with the goal of asserting superiority of a set of values over another. But this was balanced by the strong